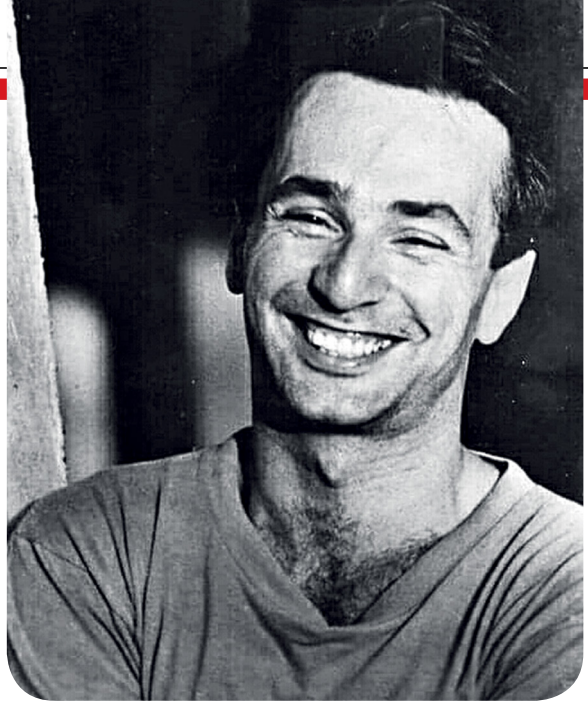


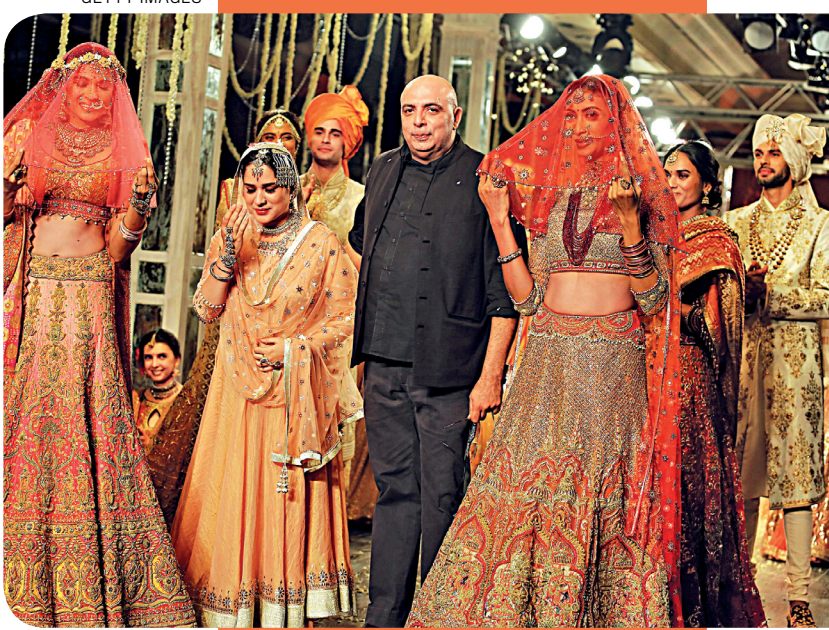
Rohit Khosla

Long before designer labels and stores, there was the ubiquitous boutique. This was where the ladies flocked to, to realise their fashion fantasies. Then, in 1987, Rohit Khosla launched Ensemble, the multi-designer boutique in Mumbai that he co-founded with Tarun and Shailja Tahiliani, and the Indian fashion world was never the same again. Ensemble was where one could buy ready-to-wear creations from Khosla's eponymous brand, Tarun Tahiliani, Abu Jani Sandeep Khosla, American designer Neil Bieff, and Amaya. Khosla pushed designer Rohit Bal to create his first menswear range, JJ Valaya interned with him, Rina Dhaka launched her own line from Khosla's atelier, and designer Ranna Gill and Nicobar's Aparna Chandra trained with the trailblazer.

Tarun Tahiliani

No one knows how to sculpt the human form with fabric better than Tarun Tahiliani. And on no one else does the epithet 'Master of Drapes' sit better than on the veteran designer as he marries luxurious Indian textile with craftsmanship to create visions of exquisiteness. If Ensemble brought the best of Indian fashion under one roof in 1987, Tahiliani took it to the world in 2003, when he became the first Indian fashion designer to showcase his collection at the Milan Fashion Week. There are no full stops in that journey, as Tahiliani recently launched his flagship boutique in Bengaluru.

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SUBIR HALDER

Ritu Kumar

The doyenne of Indian textile, Ritu Kumar elevated Indian weaves to their rightful place through her bridal and festive wear. Her journey began from a small village in West Bengal, Serampore, where she started an enterprise to help an out-of-work colony of handblock printers. Today, Kumar is a force of nature, with some 100 stores globally, and four brands to her name—Label Ritu Kumar, RI Ritu Kumar, aarké and Ritu Kumar Home. Among the first Indian designers to break into the fashion spaces of Paris and New York in the '70s, she is the recipient of a Padma Shri and the French Chevalier des arts et des lettres.